

Psalms 146

Put Not Your Trust in Princes

Put not your trust in princes, nor in the son of man, in whom there is no help
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Praise ye the LORD. Praise the LORD, O my soul.
- 2 While I live will I praise the LORD: I will sing praises unto my God while I have any being.
- 3 Put not your trust in princes, nor in the son of man, in whom there is no help.
- 4 His breath goeth forth, he returneth to his earth; in that very day his thoughts perish.
- 5 Happy is he that hath the God of Jacob for his help, whose hope is in the LORD his God:
- 6 Which made heaven, and earth, the sea, and all that therein is: which keepeth truth for ever:
- 7 Which executeth judgment for the oppressed: which giveth food to the hungry. The LORD looseth the prisoners:
- 8 The LORD openeth the eyes of the blind: the LORD raiseth them that are bowed down: the LORD loveth the righteous:
- 9 The LORD preserveth the strangers; he relieveth the fatherless and widow: but the way of the wicked he turneth upside down.
- 10 The LORD shall reign for ever, even thy God, O Zion, unto all generations. Praise ye the LORD.

2 · CONTEXT

The first of five closing hallelujah psalms, Psalm 146 contrasts the fragility of human power with the reliability of God, who alone can be trusted absolutely because His help does not expire with mortality. Its list of God's concrete acts—executing justice for the oppressed, feeding the hungry, freeing prisoners, healing the blind, protecting strangers and the vulnerable—reads almost as a job description of what genuine kingship should look like, one only God fully performs. Henry treats the psalm as a corrective aimed at every generation tempted to overestimate human leaders.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens with personal resolve: praise the Lord, O my soul; David commits to praising God for as long as he lives, framing worship as a lifelong practice rather than an occasional response.

Verse 3-4

A direct warning follows: do not put your trust in princes or in any mortal, in whom there is no lasting help. When breath departs, such a person returns to the earth, and in that very day their plans and purposes come to nothing—human power is inherently time-limited.

Verse 5-7

Contrasting blessing belongs to the one whose help and hope rest in the God of Jacob, who made heaven, earth, and sea, keeps truth forever, executes justice for the oppressed, and gives food to the hungry—power described here entirely in terms of concrete relief for the vulnerable, not grandeur for its own sake.

Verse 8-10

The list continues: God opens the eyes of the blind, raises up those bowed down, loves the righteous, watches over strangers, relieves the fatherless and widow, while overturning the way of the wicked. The psalm closes with a declaration that the Lord will reign forever, through every generation—unlike any human ruler, whose reign inevitably ends.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Human leaders, however powerful, remain mortal and time-limited, and any trust placed in them ultimately hits that limit; only God's help endures without expiration. The psalm defines true, praiseworthy power specifically by its care for the vulnerable—the oppressed, hungry, blind, bowed down, stranger, fatherless, and widow—rather than by dominance or permanence for its own sake.

Application for life today.

Examine where you may be placing the kind of ultimate trust described in verse 3 in a human leader, institution, or relationship that cannot actually bear that weight. Let the psalm's list in verses 7–9 shape your own definition of admirable power—measure leaders, including yourself, by care for the vulnerable rather than by strength or status. Return to verse 2's resolve to praise God for

as long as you live, treating worship as a lifelong practice rather than a response reserved for good seasons only.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where might you be placing a kind of ultimate trust in a human leader or institution that verse 3 warns cannot bear that weight?

2. How does the psalm's list of God's concrete acts of care for the vulnerable (vv. 7–9) challenge your own definition of praiseworthy power or leadership?

3. What would it mean to make verse 2's resolve—praising God as long as you live—a lifelong practice rather than an occasional response to good circumstances?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).